Software Development Report

An investigation into Lightweight Hand Pose estimation for Edge HCI

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1 Purpose, Operation and Validation

This software is a gesture-driven interactive demo developed for live presentation. Its purpose is to allow a demo user to explore prepared visual outputs through direct hand interaction rather than through command-line experiments or conventional desktop controls.

The primary user story for this demo is: "As a demo user, I want to control the demo through hand gestures so that I can navigate the showcase and inspect the prepared visual outputs without relying on a mouse or keyboard."

In operation, the demo opens the ZED camera, detects one hand, and uses the tracked hand as the main control input. Palm movement is used to drive an on-screen cursor, while a fist gesture is interpreted as a click. Through this interaction model, the user can move from the start page to the menu and then select either the segmentation demonstration or the tone-mapping demonstration.

The software can be considered to be working correctly when it starts successfully, detects the camera, shows stable cursor movement in response to hand motion, registers fist gestures as intended selections, allows the user to navigate the demonstration pages correctly, and updates the visual outputs in the expected way.

2 Design and Implementation

2.1 Significant Assumptions Made for the Design and Implementation

This demo assumes that a working ZED camera is connected and available at runtime, that a single hand can be tracked reliably enough for gesture-based interaction, that the application is used in its intended portrait presentation layout, that the required segmentation and tone-mapping assets are already present locally, and that the application is launched from the expected working directory so that its relative asset paths resolve correctly during execution.

2.2 Languages, Packages, Frameworks, and Libraries Used

The demo was implemented in Python 3.10, with PySide6 used for the graphical user interface, MediaPipe used for hand tracking, and `pyzed` used for interaction with the ZED camera. With support from OpenCV, Pillow and NumPy.

2.3 Overall Architecture / System Design and Interfaces Between Components

The demo was implemented as a small interactive architecture with three main parts. First, a perception pipeline acquires frames from the ZED camera, preprocesses them, and applies MediaPipe Hands to estimate landmarks from which cursor position, palm width, and fist-click state are derived. Second, a central `MainWindow` acts as the controller for the application: it receives pose updates, maintains the active page, updates the overlay, routes gesture-derived click events to the appropriate page logic, and triggers timeout recovery when tracking is lost. Third, the presentation layer is implemented as a set of pages for the start screen, menu, segmentation demonstration, and tone-mapping demonstration, with the content pages loading prepared visual assets from disk.

This structure was chosen because it separates latency-sensitive vision processing from presentation logic while still allowing both demonstrations to share the same interaction controller. The perception pipeline is responsible for deriving interaction state from live camera input, the controller manages application state and gesture routing, and the presentation layer is responsible for what the user sees. This separation reduces coupling between different responsibilities, helps

keep the interface responsive during live use, and makes the overall flow of interaction easier to understand.

Alternative designs were possible. For example, camera acquisition, hand tracking, and page behaviour could have been implemented directly inside the GUI event loop or combined within a more monolithic single-class design. However, this approach was not chosen because it would have made the application more tightly coupled, harder to reason about, and more likely to become unresponsive during live interaction. The adopted design was thus more appropriate for a demo that depended on real-time tracking and clear separation between interaction logic and presentation behaviour.

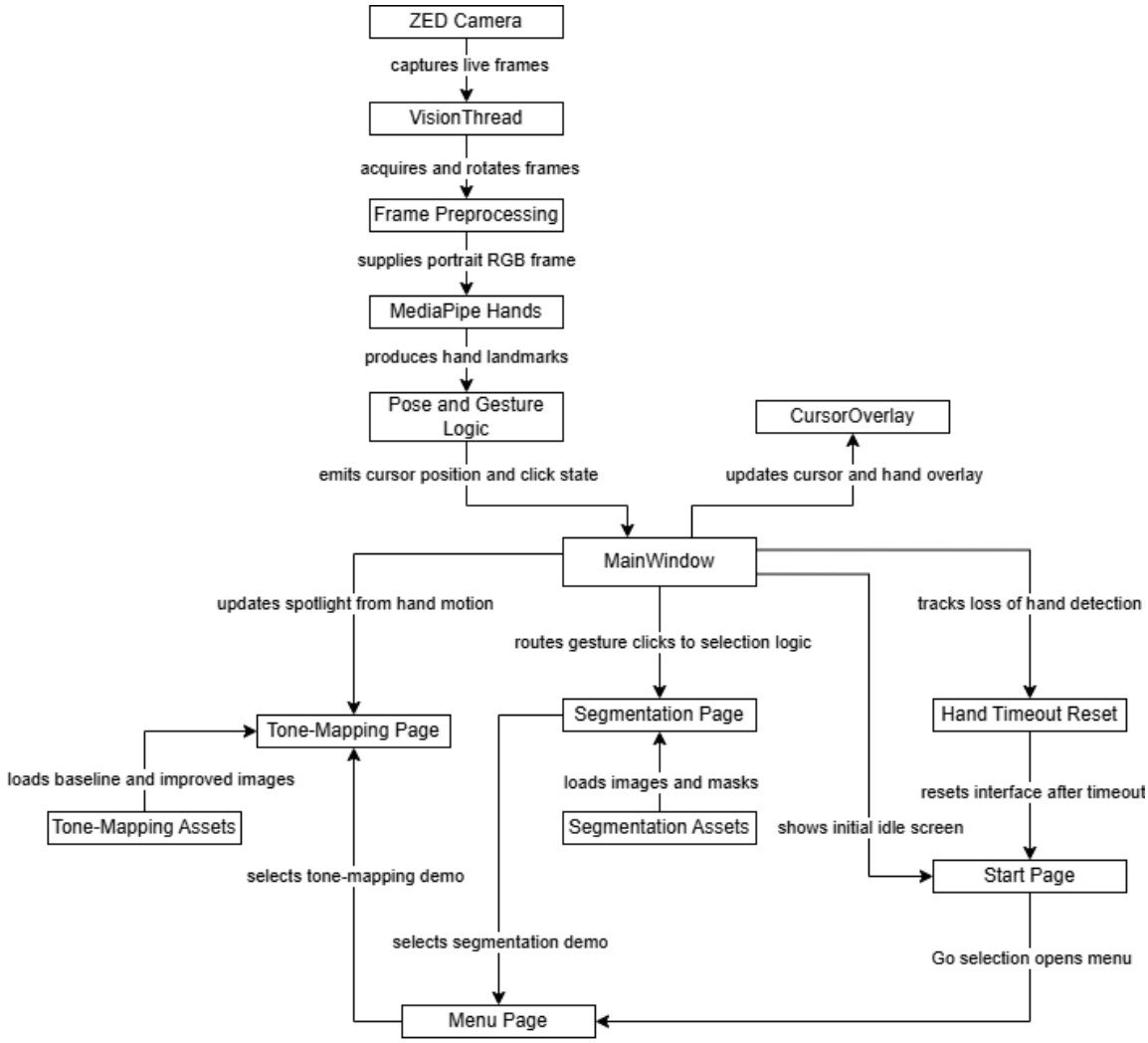

Figure 1: Architecture of the interactive demo, showing the live hand-tracking pipeline, central window controller, and gesture-driven demo pages.

2.4 Data Model(s), Including In-Memory Structures and Persistent Storage

The main runtime inputs are frames from the ZED camera together with locally stored microscopy images, masks, and tone-mapped image pairs. In memory, these are represented as image buffers, hand-tracking outputs, cursor and gesture state, connected-component overlays for the segmentation demonstration, and fixed baseline or improved image pairs for the tone-mapping demonstration. Persistent storage is file-based rather than database-based.

This data model was chosen because it matched the role of the demo as a live presentation tool rather than as a general-purpose software platform. The application needed to combine real-time camera input with a small set of prepared assets and transform them into responsive visual behaviour with as little overhead as possible. A lightweight in-memory representation was therefore appropriate, while file-based storage was sufficient because the demo uses a fixed asset set and does not need complex persistence, remote access, or long-term state management.

Alternative designs were possible. For example, the prepared assets could have been managed through a more elaborate asset-management layer or a database-backed store. The visual outputs could also have been generated dynamically rather than being read from prepared files. These approaches were not adopted because they would have introduced additional complexity without clear benefit for a demo whose purpose was to present fixed prepared outputs through gesture-based interaction. The simpler file-based and in-memory approach was therefore the more suitable design for this software.

2.5 Significant Methods, Functions, or Other Lower-Level Elements

The most significant lower-level elements in this demonstrator are the helper functions and classes that convert hand landmarks into usable interaction behaviour. Functions such as `palm_center`, `palm_width`, `tip_mcp_norm`, and `is_fist` in `mp_handpose_demo/hand_18.py` are important because they define how the software derives cursor position, hand scale, and click-like gesture state from the tracked hand landmarks.

The `VisionThread` class, performs live camera acquisition, frame preprocessing, MediaPipe hand tracking, and click debouncing before emitting pose updates to the rest of the application. forming the main runtime bridge between raw camera input and the higher-level gesture-driven behaviour seen by the user.

The presentation behaviour of the demonstrator is implemented mainly through `CursorOverlay`, `SegmentationDemoWidget`, `MultiMaskSegmentationWidget`, and `ToneMappingDemoWidget`. These classes are significant because they implement the visible behaviour of the two demonstrations: drawing the live overlay, resolving clicked segmentation regions, revealing RNvU masks, and displaying the hand-controlled tone-mapping spotlight. The `MainWindow` class coordinates these components and routes the gesture-derived events that connect tracking input to page behaviour.

2.6 Important Errors and Their Conditions

The software may fail to start correctly if the ZED camera is not connected, cannot be opened, or is otherwise unavailable at runtime. Parts of the demonstrator may fail or display incomplete behaviour if required images or mask files are missing, unreadable, or empty. Because the implementation uses relative asset paths, the software also depends on being launched from the expected working directory so that those paths resolve correctly. Even when the application starts successfully, behaviour may degrade if the user's hand is not tracked reliably, if gesture detection is unstable, or if tracking is lost during use. Under these conditions, cursor motion may become unstable, intended selections may not register correctly, or the interface may return to the start screen after the configured timeout.

2.7 User Interface Design

The interaction logic is implemented explicitly rather than through a generic gesture library. The cursor position is derived from the mean position of a small set of palm-related landmarks, mirrored horizontally to match user expectation, and then smoothed before being displayed so that motion appears stable rather than jittery. A fist is detected by comparing fingertip-to-base

distances against palm width, and clicks are debounced so that one closing motion does not trigger repeated activations. If no hand is detected for a short timeout period, the interface automatically returns to the start screen, which helps recover from tracking loss during live use. In practical terms, this gives the demo two forms of interaction: continuous hand motion is used to control cursor-like behaviour, while discrete fist closures are used as selection events for navigation and page-specific actions.

The first demonstration is event-driven. It presents microscopy imagery together with precomputed segmentation data, and a user selection event determines which prepared overlay is revealed. In one mode, a binary mask is converted into connected components and the selected component is highlighted when the user clicks on the image. In another mode, multiple precomputed RNvU retina masks are loaded and the mask covering the selected pixel is revealed.

The second demonstration is continuous rather than event-driven. It presents tone-mapping results using paired images: a baseline image is shown across the whole display, while an improved image is revealed only inside a hand-controlled spotlight. The spotlight position follows the gesture-controlled cursor and its radius scales with palm width, so hand motion acts as a live control input rather than as a sequence of clicks. In both demonstrations, the software does not run segmentation or tone-mapping models live. It instead provides an interaction layer for exploring prepared outputs visually.

2.8 Quality Assurance Steps

2.8.1 Version Control and Versioning

Development of the demonstrator was managed through Git-based version control. This made it possible to track changes to the application logic, documentation, and bundled assets while the interaction model and presentation flow were still being refined.

2.8.2 Code Style and Convention

Although the demonstrator is implemented largely in a single file, a consistent internal structure was used to keep the code understandable. Configuration constants are grouped near the top of the file, helper functions implement the gesture calculations, dedicated widget classes encapsulate the different demo views, and the `MainWindow` class coordinates page flow and interaction state. Descriptive naming and lightweight inline documentation were used to keep the behaviour clear during development.